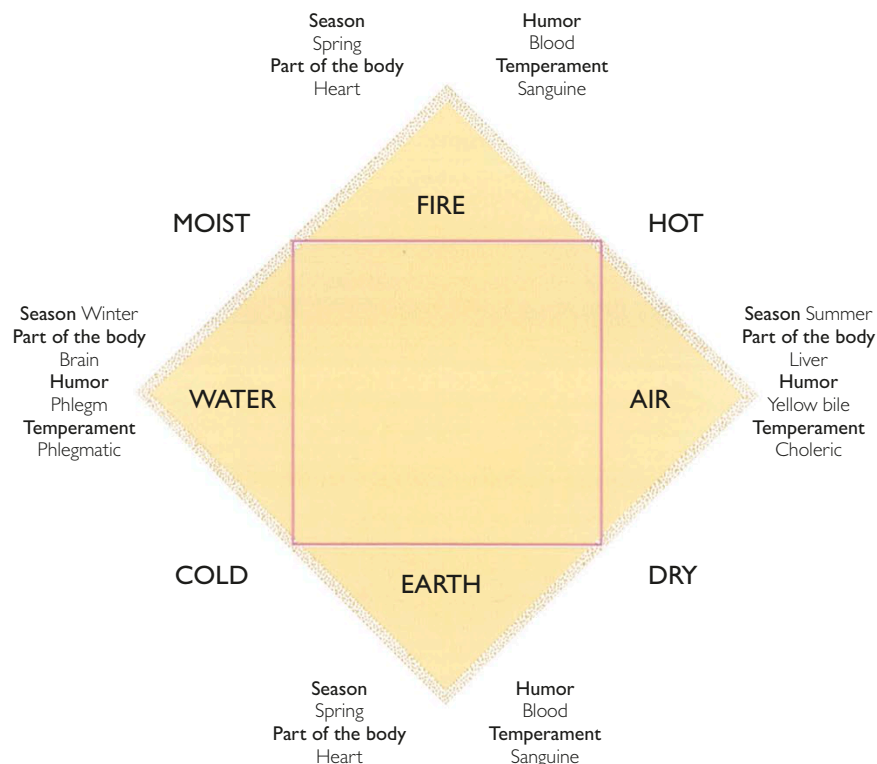




The ancient theory of the four humors holds that four fluids within the body—black bile, phlegm, yellow bile, and blood—correspond to the four elements (earth, water, air, and fire), the four seasons, and other aspects of the natural world. Until the 17th century, physicians believed that an imbalance of the humoral system caused mental and physical illness.

mandrake (*Mandragora officinarum*, see p. 232). With a forked root that resembles the human shape, mandrake was credited with great magical and healing powers. It was recommended by Dioscorides for many ailments, including sleeplessness and inflammation of the eyes.

With the collapse of the Roman empire in the 5th century CE, the debate about how illness arose and how it should be treated shifted to the East. By the 9th century, Islamic physicians had translated much of Galen's work into Arabic, and his ideas affected the development of Arabic medicine into the Middle Ages, influencing Avicenna (980–1037). Later in the Middle Ages, Galen's writings were translated back into Latin from the Arabic and, for 400 years, his ideas held sway and were diligently applied in European medical practice. Even in the 16th and 17th centuries, students in university medical schools were given an academic training in the principles of the humoral system, as established by Galen. They learned how to diagnose an imbalance of the humors, and the methods of restoring equilibrium, primarily bloodletting and purging (see pp. 23–24).

Printing & Herbal Medicine

The invention of printing in the 15th century changed the face of herbal medicine in Europe. Before that time, European folk medicine had been handed down from generation to generation. While some early herbals were written in Anglo-Saxon, Icelandic, and Welsh, for example, for the most part the tradition was orally based.

During the following centuries, herbals were published throughout Europe in different languages, making standardized catalogs of herbs and their applications accessible to the general public, not just to those who understood Latin. As literacy rates rose, women in particular used the advice in the herbals to treat their families.

Fresh hops

Dried hops

Hops (*Humulus lupulus*, p. 104) are generally sedative, but they also stimulate digestive function.

Feverfew (*Tanacetum parthenium*, p. 140) is hailed as a breakthrough treatment for migraine.

Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*, p. 56) may have been used by Achilles' troops in the Trojan war to staunch bleeding.

Angelica (*Angelica archangelica*, p. 168) treats indigestion.

Chaste tree (*Vitex agnus-castus*, p. 151) relieves menopausal problems.

Nettle (*Urtica dioica*, p. 146) treats anemia.

Hyssop (*Hyssopus officinalis*, p. 222) was prescribed by Hippocrates for pleurisy.

Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128) is traditionally taken to improve the memory.

Cramp bark (*Viburnum opulus*, p. 150) relaxes muscles.

Cramp bark berries